

This is a time for Everyone to come to church, although not all at once!

Saturday before the Sunday of the Cross, March 8/21, 2020. *Revised Letter*

Dear Faithful in Christ:

I want to make sure there are no misunderstandings between us. Father Nicholas and I have a difficult task, to increase the services, and make the Holy Mysteries and confession and other things available to everyone that needs them, and yet also to follow the rules of the secular authorities, and our diocese, which our bishop has said we must follow.

I don't want anyone to get hurt feelings. We are not showing any favoritism. Our own family members are not always allowed to go to church. In order to conduct the services properly, of course there must be a priest, and someone who knows how to sing. That leaves only 8 more "slots". We are trying our best to include everyone who wants to come to the services. This should be all of you, even those of you who don't normally come to church often or for every weekend. Remember that there are services every day, and communion every day. Keep that in mind, and if you could come during the week, there is no difference between Holy Communion in Presanctified Liturgy, on a Tuesday vs a Sunday morning. For most people their secular life is no longer "business as usual", and it must be even more so for your spiritual life. This is a time to be more pious, and confess and commune, if possible, more often.

We've done an extraordinary thing, by making Holy Communion available after the liturgy for as long as we need to be there. I will be perfectly honest with you, and tell you that I will be extremely disappointed if there are not at least 60 people that want to have communion after the liturgy has ended.

We are living in extraordinary times, and very difficult times. The toll extracted from this virus will be very large. Not only is there loss of life, but there is loss of livelihood, and possibly, depending on how the secular states continue to react, the loss of our religious freedom. Also, some of us might be losing our senses, and not having the right priorities. There is fear everywhere, and misinformation and disinformation. All of those losses are real, and large.

I entreat you as your pastor, and I'm sure Fr Nicholas would agree with me, that you must prioritize prayer. You must not be afraid of coming to the church to receive communion. If you are afraid, you should speak to us. We are complying by all regulations. The state does not understand that we have a higher regulation to comply with that we are also obeying, and that is that we pray and that we conduct the holy services, especially the Eucharist.

Our novel method of giving Communion to everyone who wishes it will only be successful if you come to the church.

There only eight people other than the priests that can come to the Sunday liturgy (on other days, only one priest is serving, in order to make another slot available), but all of you can come to the church parking lot, remain in your cars or stand near them without congregating, say the Typica prayers, which are required for you to commune, and then, as you are called, come in for confession if needed or desired, and commune the Holy Mysteries. This is our way, and should be your way of showing to the world and to yourself if you are a Christian that you react to pestilence in a Christian way.

It is very difficult to keep track of everyone's requests. We are trying the best we can. If we have not responded to you, but please be patient with us. We are sending out text/email invitations to those that can come to the service. There's no favoritism here, and nobody is considered to be more special than the others. It's merely a numbers game. We must obey the state, and we must conduct the services.

We are not like many other churches, literally shutting their doors and not having any services; We are Orthodox Christians, and we will not do that unless the state literally bars us, and even in that case, we might have to make a different decision if their rules go on for a long time.

You must pray more than you normally do. This may be a new experience for some of you. This is why I'm requiring that you say the Typica prayers in order to have the Holy Mysteries (of course this applies to those who do not attend the liturgy). This is not a time for us to become softer, take our ease, or to watch Netflix on Sunday morning. You should treat Sunday morning as any Sunday, except that you don't come to the church until after the service is over, and you wait to be called in. Keep your fast on Sunday morning as you usually do. Obviously, if you need to eat because taking medication or a medical condition, the same rules apply as before. Those who come to the church for the service on Saturday, you are obliged to also come for communion on Sunday, unless there is extreme need.

Here is the procedure for those who come to the church after the liturgy to receive the Holy Mysteries. Please note that any instructions in this letter could change. I changed something in the letter I sent this morning because I was told to by the diocese.

When you come to the church for communion after the Divine Liturgy, please come through the hall door (Someone will be opening the door for you so you don't have to touch it), and go directly to the kitchen sink and wash your hands well with soap and water.

You should take at least 30 seconds to wash. You can turn the water on with your elbow. Use the control in the center not the individual controls, which will already be set. Work up a good lather. Rub the insides of your hands together for five seconds, and the outsides of your hands for five seconds each, then put your fingers together and rub in between your fingers for five seconds, and then for five seconds each rub your fingertips against your palm. Then rinse for five seconds. If you say the long form of the Jesus prayer not too quickly it's about five seconds: "Lord Jesus Christ, son of God, have mercy on me a sinner". Dry with a paper towel.

If you feel ill, if you ask us, we will come to you at your home. Fr Nicholas and I are not afraid of getting a disease because we give you communion. We must be careful about spreading disease in other circumstances, such as touching doors and surfaces and the like. Please note that the same rules apply: you must say your Preparation Prayers and the Typica service, and keep your fast, except in the case of medical need. If we are coming much later in the day, you must use your intelligence, which God has given you, about your need for food or drink. If there is some reason that you are not able to comply with any of these directives, you should talk to me. If you're very ill, then there is a reason to relax these directives, but if you merely have a cold or the flu, and are not bedridden, these directives may be difficult to follow because you're not accustomed to so much prayer on Sunday morning by yourself, but we can do anything we put our minds to. *Please note that these directives may change.*

We will give confession to those who need or desire it, by standing at some distance from one another. Then we will give you absolution. You may write your sins on a piece of paper to facilitate the discussion. This is always a good practice in general. *Please note that these directives may change.*

Fr Nicholas and I are aware that everyone has unique needs. There may be some of you that are suffering financially, or do not have food. Please make us aware of anything you think we should know about, and will try to address it.

May God bless you and help you in all things.

Links and Information

Google Form: <https://forms.gle/2JbPDstxa8MVoTzA7> (Fill this out in order to be considered for attendance of any of our MANY services)

- Priest Seraphim Holland seraphim@orthodox.net 972 658-5433
- Priest Nicholas Park frnicholas@orthodox.net 972 839-2439
- Church Web Page: <http://www.orthodox.net> Church Facebook Page: <https://www.facebook.com/orthodoxnet/>
- EMAIL List: <http://groups.google.com/group/saint-nicholas-orthodox-church>

Typica: <http://www.orthodox.net/services/typica-sunday-of-the-cross-2020-03-22-ns.doc> (Complete file for the 3rd Sunday of Great Lent)
<https://fatherjohn.blogspot.com/2020/03/doing-typika-at-home.html>

Полный чин Обедницы для мирян можно скачать здесь: https://sinod.ruschurchabroad.org/bib_obednitsa-dlia-mirian.pdf

Other recommended Prayers: [*A Moleben sung in time of devastating epidemic and death-bearing pestilence. Abbreviated, for use when no priest is present.*](#)

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/moleben-pestilence-reader.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/moleben-pestilence-reader.doc>

Prayers to St Nikephoros: <http://www.orthodox.net/articles/prayer-to-nikephoros-the-leper-during-the-coronavirus-pandemic.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/articles/prayer-to-nikephoros-the-leper-during-the-coronavirus-pandemic.doc>

Akathist to our Sweetest Lord Jesus Christ : <http://stjohnah.org/akathist-to-our-sweetest-lord-jesus-christ>

Akathist to the Most Holy Theotokos: http://www.fatheralexander.org/booklets/english/m_akathist_e.htm

Supplicatory Canon to the Most Holy Theotokos:

http://web.archive.org/web/20001204003900/http://pages.prodigy.net/frjohnwhiteford/mpthn_canon.htm

This Letter: http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-06_2020-03-21.html

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-06_2020-03-21.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-05_2020-03-19.pdf

Previous Pastoral Letters: http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-04_2020-03-17.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-04_2020-03-17.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-03_2020-03-17.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-02_2020-03-14.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-02_2020-03-14.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-02_2020-03-14.pdf

Coronavirus Instructional Letter by Archbishop Peter (March 4/17,2020) : https://chicagodiocese.org/news_200317_1

Second Revised Mayoral Declaration of Local State of Disaster Due to Public Health Emergency:

<https://www.mckinneytexas.org/DocumentCenter/View/22842/Mayor-Declaration-Update-3-17-20-signed>